

Speech by President António Costa at the 47th colloquium on international relations at the University of Minho

It is a great pleasure for me to be here with you today in such a special academic year for the University of Minho, as it celebrates 50 years of the degree course in international relations, the first of its kind in Portugal.

It is also remarkable that the colloquia on international relations have been taking place for 47 uninterrupted years, since 1980. That year was a stepping stone – five years after our decolonisation, five years before the signing of the Treaty of Accession to the European Union, when, as I have said, we had to reinvent our place in the world. In particular, the centre for international relations studies, which has been the driving force behind this initiative.

In a rapidly changing world, it is comforting to see that some things stay the same. One of those things is the spirit of innovation at the University of Minho. It is the commitment of young academics and researchers to understanding and reflecting on global challenges.

Let me start with a simple question. What do international relations look like today? I imagine that your answer will be immediate and very similar to my own. Increasingly disrupted. But if we look more closely, we can identify two main trends.

On the one hand, increasing violations of the rules-based international order that has been in place since the post-war period. A world in which the power of might seems to prevail over the power of the law, where international law is frequently disregarded and where great powers violate peace and disrupt global trade.

On the other hand, the world is also becoming increasingly multipolar. More emerging economies are growing in scale, confidence and power. More medium-sized countries aspire to play a significant role.

It is precisely the combination of these two trends – the erosion of respect for international law and the rise of multipolarity – that is shaping the major challenge facing the European Union. So what is the EU's strategy in the current global context? I would try to summarise it in five Ps:

- principles
- peace
- prosperity
- partnerships
- power

Let's take a look at the principles. The EU must wholeheartedly support a rules-based international order, anchored in the principles of the United Nations Charter, the defence of human rights, the peaceful resolution of conflicts, and respect for the sovereignty of states, their territorial integrity and the stability of their internationally recognised borders.

Of course, the United Nations and the multilateral system must be reformed and modernised. The Security Council clearly no longer corresponds to the reality of the modern world. But it is one thing to reform, and another to eliminate. The United Nations must be reformed, but the United Nations cannot be replaced.

It must remain the cornerstone of the multilateral system, because it is the only universally legitimate forum with the power to sustain effective multilateral cooperation, without which is impossible to tackle global challenges. As the largest donor of international aid in the world, and the largest donor to the UN agencies, the EU will continue to take the lead in global solidarity, especially at a time when the UN system is facing serious financial constraints. Because the opposite of cooperation is conflict and the opposite of rules is chaos.

And chaos leads only to more violence. We can see the chaos in Ukraine, in the Middle East, in Gaza and in Sudan. These conflicts do not only threaten peace.

They also threaten the prosperity of our citizens and global stability. It is therefore in our interest to ensure that the world

continues to cooperate on the basis of rules accepted by all. Portugal knows this well, and a brief history of these colloquia clearly demonstrates the power of international law.

At one of your previous colloquia you received the current President of the Republic and Nobel Peace Prize laureate, José Ramos-Horta. The struggle of the Timorese people and the guarantee of their independence would never have been successful without global society's commitment to international law. We are talking about a small territory that makes up less than half of an island, just one of the thousands of islands of the Indonesian archipelago.

Nevertheless, after a decade and a half of occupation, international law was able to prevail. Without the strength that international law then had, Timor-Leste would never have been the independent nation it is today. We must bear that in mind when we think about ourselves, and understand that it is crucial for medium-sized countries and regions that the defence of international law prevail over the logic of force.

Secondly, peace.

Peace is in the European Union's DNA. The European Union is a peace project born from the rubble of the Second World War.

And peace has always been the driving force for relations between the European Union's growing number of Member States, and for the way it conducts itself in the world. A permanent and lasting peace based on shared principles that bring well-being and prosperity for all. Therefore, since the very first day of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the European Union has supported that country politically, financially, diplomatically and militarily, and will continue to do so until a just and lasting peace is achieved.

We do not only do so for Ukraine and the Ukrainians. We also do so in defence of the principles of international law. We do so in defence of the United Nations Charter.

Because the right to sovereignty, to territorial integrity and to stability of internationally recognised borders are universal principles. They are essential in Ukraine, they are essential in Venezuela, and they are essential in every part of the world. And the Ukrainian people's legitimate right to self-defence is absolutely essential.

I would add another right. Ukraine's right to freely choose the future it wants, just as we are able to choose. And its will is to join the European Union.

To be part of the family of Europe, with its values of freedom, democracy, human rights, multilateralism, the social economy and the market economy. Ukraine's future, like that of the Western Balkans and Moldova, lies in the European Union, because for us too, enlargement is the best geopolitical investment we can make in Europe's peace and prosperity.

In the year when Portugal marks 40 years as a member of the European Union, it has a duty to appreciate the particular importance of recognising that right to self-determination.

We have been far too slow to recognise the right of colonised people to self-determination. But we were able to exercise that right to self-determination when we decided to join the European Union, and it is with that self-determination that we choose to remain in the European Union and contribute to its further development. Considering the benefits that we ourselves have enjoyed, we must recognise everybody else's right to benefit from exercising that same freedom and that same right.

Thirdly, prosperity.

This is the third P, which requires a roadmap based on an energy transition that reduces our dependency on fossil energy, promotes renewable energy sources, and continues to prioritise the fight against climate change.

We remain committed to the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals and Pact for the Future.

We remain committed to the Paris Agreement and the targets of reducing greenhouse gas emissions by 55% by 2030 and achieving climate neutrality by 2050. When we recently agreed on an intermediate target of reducing emissions by 90% by 2040, we wished to signal that we have not changed our minds, that we are committed, and that we wish to pursue this transition process with the same intensity and the same effort. And we are dedicated to protecting the oceans and implementing the High Seas Treaty to safeguard the biodiversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction.

But as became clear with Russia's invasion of Ukraine, and now all the more so with the current conflict in the Middle East and the blockades in the Strait of Hormuz, Europe cannot maintain its current energy dependencies if it is to achieve true autonomy. It is very clear today that investing in the energy transition is not just about contributing to the future of the planet, but also about making a decisive contribution to our security. Due to its geographical position, Europe has a 360° view of various points of conflict.

We have experienced the energy crisis caused by the disruption of the gas supply from Russia. Now we are experiencing the energy crisis caused by the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

Nobody is more dependent on imported fossil energy than Europe. Nobody is in a better position than Europe to produce its own energy, whether from renewable or from nuclear sources.

We have been moving in that direction since 2022, drastically reducing our energy dependence on Russia. But we must go further.

Europe needs to decarbonise, as Portugal has done successfully, with 80% of the electricity it consumes now being generated from renewable sources. It needs to innovate technologically and to reindustrialise, making supply chains safer and more predictable.

An ongoing prosperity roadmap that will bring more quality jobs, better wages, more affordable housing, better public services and greater intergenerational justice. Strong welfare states, affordable housing and high-quality jobs are not barriers to competitiveness. On the contrary, they are a precondition and a foundation for it. That is something we must never forget. Social Europe as a social market economy is an essential feature of our collective DNA, and provides the basis for the social contract upon which we have rebuilt a lasting peace in Europe since the Second World War.

Let us move on to partnerships. In this multipolar world we need to understand that the world cannot be shaped by a single power, nor by the division of the globe into new spheres of influence. We experienced that during the Cold War and do not want to repeat it. We live in a multipolar world that requires multilateral solutions and strategic partnerships.

The European Union has therefore been strengthening its ties with Canada, India, Brazil, Mexico, the United Kingdom, Japan, South Korea, Australia, Indonesia, South Africa, and many others. Over the last year alone we have held high-level summits with all of the BRICS countries, except for Russia, and also with the countries of Central Asia, with the African Union, and with the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States. In total, these states account for 62% of the population represented by the United Nations

This demonstrates that both the North and the South are pluralist and can share long-term commitments to achieving shared objectives.

My recent visit to three Gulf countries, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates, and the fact that the Presidents of Syria, Lebanon and Egypt, and the Crown Prince of the Kingdom of Jordan, attended last week's Informal Council in Cyprus, are a testament to that commitment to lasting peace and security.

I can assure you that there is an immense shared will between these partners and the European Union to end this war, the naval blockades and the suffering of the people. But there is also a commitment to speeding up the trade agenda.

Testament to this are the recent trade agreements with Mercosur and India, from which some 3 billion people benefit. Those two agreements can be added to the agreements the European Union already has in place with some 80 countries,

partnerships that are absolutely crucial to peace, climate action, the regulation of the international economy, food security and multilateral global governance. Our ambition is to extend those trade partnerships to the 27 countries with which new trade agreements are being negotiated or already being ratified. And that is what we will continue to do for the sake of Europe's role and for the world. Because rather than spheres of influence, we are creating spheres of shared prosperity.

And one thing is certain. The European Union is the world's largest trading power. And through these trade agreements, it can make a decisive contribution to stabilising international economic relations. In other words, to the stability of the global economy.

Lastly, let us talk about the last P – Power.

An aspect that the European Union must be able to address with greater confidence.

After all:

- we are one of the three largest economies in the world
- we have the second strongest currency
- we are the largest global trading power
- the largest donor of development aid
- and we have created the world's leading space for economic well-being and social justice

We therefore have reasons to be proud. But we can and must go further. First and foremost by increasing trust in ourselves. The diversity of the European Union is not a problem. It is a source of wealth for the European Union. It's true. Deciding to sign executive orders is faster than reaching agreement among 27 countries.

But reaching agreement among 27 countries has power derived from sharing and common sense, and the collective reflection of those 27 countries produces a solid sense of wisdom that contributes to peace on a global scale. Of course, we want to be able to take decisions more quickly, but perhaps more important than the time it takes is the quality of the decision. And the fact is that,

over the decades of the European Union's existence, it may not always have acted swiftly, but on the whole, it has made the right decisions.

Talking about European power today means addressing two pillars that are essential if we are to overcome our own vulnerabilities in the areas of competitiveness and defence. We wanted to make 2025 the year of defence. We began with a day of reflection, we set out our guidelines, and we concluded by agreeing on a series of key measures to strengthen defence in Europe. 2026 must be the year of competitiveness in Europe. Both are crucial pillars of European sovereignty.

In the defence sector, we have established a readiness strategy that will take us up to 2030, we have identified priority military capabilities, we have developed mechanisms to build these up jointly and we have created European instruments to provide funding or budgetary leeway for member states to make the investments they have decided on or which they have committed to make within the framework of NATO.

For competitiveness, we set out the scope and ambition in the brainstorming session we held last month in Alden Biesen and we took the important decisions at the European Council in March. These set out an ambitious 'One Europe, One Market' agenda, which involves completing the single market, pursuing the strategy of simplification, ensuring affordable energy, supporting innovation, reducing strategic dependencies and, above all, completing what has been in the pipeline since 1992: a capital union, a unified energy market and a unified telecommunications market.

Last week, the European Commission, the Council and the European Parliament signed a roadmap containing tangible commitments on the timetable for presenting initiatives and their adoption by the legislative bodies, with a view to having concluded the 'One Europe, One Market' agenda by the end of 2027.

A roadmap providing for:

- targets for legislative proposals
- a quarterly review of progress
- clear institutional responsibilities for all institutions
- regular assessments to ensure full transparency

A roadmap that will boost Europe's economic growth, secure our digital transformation and strengthen our economic and industrial resilience. A roadmap that will create jobs and make life more accessible, starting with housing, but also involving better public services and greater social justice. These are the pillars that strengthen Europe's geopolitical muscle and strategic autonomy. Europe will not be strong without the ability to defend itself and nor will it be strong without a more prosperous, dynamic and competitive economy.

These are the pillars that maximise our influence in the midst of major international crises and which strengthen our diplomacy. Without them, we cannot be a more influential independent actor or a guarantor of greater global stability. If there is one clear lesson we have learnt, it is that we must rely more on ourselves and be less dependent on others – less dependent on others for energy, less dependent on others for imports, but also less dependent on others in terms of our ability to defend ourselves against the various threats that surround us.

We are trustworthy and predictable partners, but we have learnt that not all partners are trustworthy and predictable. This is why we need a stronger Europe to be able to effectively fulfil our strategy. And we can do this.

I will give you two recent examples proving the effects of strengthening the Union's geopolitical muscle. A few weeks ago, we tested the mutual assistance mechanism provided for in Article 42(7) of the Treaty of Lisbon, when, in response to Hezbollah's attack on Cyprus, Greece, France, Italy, Spain and the Netherlands sent military forces to protect Cyprus from external attacks. And perhaps most strikingly, the way in which, by standing united, we have been able to defend the territorial integrity of the Kingdom of Denmark in the face of threats to annex Greenland, part of its territory.

The concept of strategic autonomy, which was controversial among Europeans a few years ago, is now central to how Europe sees itself and how it projects itself on the world stage. And I would go even further: those who once saw strategic autonomy as a threat to the Transatlantic Alliance have, I believe, now come to realise that only strategic autonomy can truly guarantee a future for the Transatlantic Alliance. It is an inevitable path, agreed upon by the member states, accepted by our societies, and on course to achieve these objectives as soon as possible.

And there is no time to lose, because the challenges we face are becoming more urgent with each passing day. A path that gives us greater confidence in our abilities and a deeper sense of self-worth in the unique project of peace and prosperity that is the European Union.

A Union created to ensure that our future, your future, is more sustainable, more peaceful and more prosperous. And above all, one in which all European citizens participate more and are more actively engaged, in defence of the values and principles of our – and your – European Union.

Thank you very much.

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